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BONUS GUIDE 2 OF 4

The ATS Resume Guide

How applicant tracking systems actually read your resume — and how to format so you never get filtered out before a human sees it.

01

What an ATS Actually Does

An Applicant Tracking System (ATS) is software that most mid-size and large employers use to collect, sort, and search resumes. When you apply online, your resume is almost never read by a person first — it's parsed into a database record: name, contact info, work history, education, and skills, each dropped into a field.

The problem: that parsing step is dumb. It reads left to right, top to bottom, and has no idea what a table, text box, or header/footer is supposed to mean. If your layout confuses it, your information lands in the wrong field — or gets dropped entirely — and a recruiter searching for "5 years project management" never finds you, even though you have exactly that.

02

What Breaks ATS Parsing

- Multi-column layouts and sidebars — text gets read out of order or merged together
- Tables and text boxes — many ATS platforms skip their contents entirely
- Text inside images or icons — never read at all
- Headers and footers — some systems ignore this content completely
- Unusual fonts or heavy graphics — can cause garbled text extraction
- Non-standard section titles — "Where I've Made an Impact" instead of "Experience" may not get recognized

TIP

This is exactly why this template is built the way it is: single column, real selectable text, standard section headers, no tables. It's designed to parse cleanly first, and look sharp to a human second.

03

Keyword Matching

Beyond parsing, most ATS platforms also rank or filter resumes by keyword match against the job posting. This is the single highest-leverage thing you can do per application.

HOW TO DO IT

- Paste the job posting into a doc and highlight every skill, tool, certification, and qualification mentioned
- Check your resume for each one — use the exact phrasing from the posting where it's true of you (e.g., "electronic health records (EHR)" not just "medical software")
- Work the closest, most relevant terms into your summary and your most recent role's bullets — that's where ATS ranking weighs most heavily

- Never add a skill or credential you don't actually have just to match — it will surface in the interview

04

Tailoring Per Application

You do not need a different resume for every job — you need the same strong resume with 5–10 minutes of targeted edits per application: swap in the posting's terminology, reorder bullets so the most relevant ones lead, and adjust your summary's first line to mirror the job title.

EXAMPLE

Applying to a role with a specific job title in the posting — "Family Nurse Practitioner," "Clinical Director," "Practice Administrator"? Match their exact wording in your summary line — many ATS platforms weight exact title matches heavily, whether you're in a clinical role or a healthcare leadership one.

05

ATS-Safe Formatting Checklist

- Single column, top to bottom — no side-by-side sections
- Standard section headers: Experience, Education, Skills, Certifications
- No tables, text boxes, headers, or footers
- Dates and job titles as plain text, not inside graphics
- Standard fonts (avoid anything highly decorative)
- File saved as .docx or PDF with selectable (not scanned/image) text
- File named clearly: FirstName_LastName_Resume

TIP

When in doubt, copy your resume text and paste it into a blank document. If it reads in a sensible order with nothing jumbled, an ATS will read it the same way.